



POLL-TIME THEATRE BJP's Anup Kumar Saha shaves a voter; TMC's Partha Hazari makes rotis

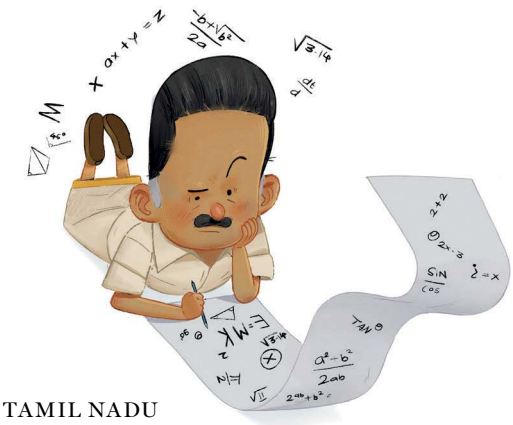
simply arrived mid-shave; anyway, his jawline was on the line while his whiskers got trimmed like voter's names in an SIR. Not far away, in Hooghly's Pursurah, Partha Hazari of the Trinamool Congress walked into a home and began making rotis. Thankfully, there seemed to be cooking gas. If fuel was running out anywhere, Mita Bag of the TMC had a solution to that too. In Sabang, Paschim Medinipur, she was seen helping dry cow dung cakes. Before anyone takes to the kitchen, there has to be food, of course. Tending to this expediency was Biman Ghosh of the BJP, who took to ploughing fields in Pursurah. Dr Sharadwat Mukherjee, BJP candidate from Bidhannagar, pitched in there too, carrying a katla fish all through the campaign, perhaps to assure the electorate that the saffronistas wouldn't impose vegetarianism on Bengal!

Whoever gets the award must thank former actor Hiran Chatterjee, the outgoing MLA from Kharagpur Sadar. While campaigning for the Lok Sabha seat of Medinipur in 2024, he had posed with a voter covered in soap, trying to bathe! One word of caution. Hiran *babu* lost that election, and is now essaying his previous, less ambitious role: as a candidate from Shyampur. Well, politics can be a humbling performance in itself.

intended—all the way across the peninsula. Any future "operation" by India could see retaliation stretch all the way to Kolkata, quoth he. Mamata Banerjee, not one to miss any random chance for rhetorical ammunition, pounced on that, asking why Prime Minister Narendra Modi had lost his usually stentorian voice. Shouldn't he have acknowledged this threat to Bengal? This recourse to high geopolitics was made to the unsuspecting masses gathered at Nadia's Bethuadahari, whose horizons are likelier set on the Radcliffe Line closer home.



(EPS), half-way to a sashtanga namaskaram before V.K. Sasikala, seated a la her mentress. It happened in 2017, when she was left bereft of CMship by an SC stricture. Look how he's "crawling" to power, Stalin Jr has been saying. "Am I a snake or lizard," EPS replies, saying seeking blessings was part of Indian culture. Sasikala, now a foe, won't be offering any.



Illustrations by SIDDHANT JUMDE

▼ TAMIL NADU

Whatever's Left

Being solid on your Marx is no guarantee that you're good with math. The Communist parties in TN have seen their marks cut even before the exam. Both the CPI(M) and CPI have suffered a trim in their share of tickets: they agreed, allegedly willingly, to settle for five seats each, one less than last time, in aid of the 'larger cause' of defeating the BJP. The Viduthalai Chiruthaigal Katchi made concessions too. But **Stalin** has funnelled some of that surplus to the DMDK, a 'has-been' party. It's dialectical.

By **Arkamoy Datta Majumdar and Kavitha Muralidharan**